

Canon No. 1

By IDC reports Canon topped the 2010 compact camera makers ranking with highest numbers shipped. Sony was at second place

PlayStation Network targeted

Sony had to recently suspend its PlayStation Network for rebuilding as a result of external intrusion. PlayStation Network has around 70 million users

Camera test

vividness that one expects from a camera, and its output seemed to lack a bit of life, for lack of a better description. Additionally, even at the same shutter speed and aperture, the image seemed to be slightly underexposed, which only added to the problem. Obviously we could have remedied this and changed settings, but the test was not about tweaking each camera to look its best, rather than presenting them in a common light, if you'll pardon the unintentional pun.

The SX130 IS seems to be the least focussed of the four wide on, but at the longer end of the zoom, tightens up on this parameter a bit. Canons output is punchy, but lacks a bit of extra highlights on some objects, the image could be termed as lifelike, or a little less vivid, but most people shopping at this price range like bright, vivid and such, which might explain Canons relatively lower popularity in the lower price rungs. If you're looking at shooting at higher ISO settings, the Coolpix S8100 will be your best bet. The SX130 IS has the best zoom, but its poor LCD and AA batteries are turn offs.

The best value for money in this group was the Canon IXUS 130, and at a shade under 10,000 bucks is your best bet for a compact camera if zoom is not a concern, it also won our Best Buy Award. If zoom is your thing, the Nikon Coolpix is your Best Buy, at an MRP of ₹13,450.

PREMIUM COMPACTS (OVER ₹15,000): SPEND MORE GET MORE?

Now why would someone spend upward of ₹20,000 on a camera and not buy a dSLR, or even an ultra zoom? More importantly, what makes a ₹15,000 camera any less than a ₹25,000 one, given their feature sets on paper look pretty similar? These were

some of the questions that we intended to solve, after all, Canon offers an IXUS 130 for ₹10,000, and then an IXUS 210 for a cool ₹21,995 and an IXUS 1000 HS for a staggering ₹25,995 – a price at which you can pick up a Canon EOS 1000D – a dSLR, albeit an entry-level one. So what makes a camera worth so much?

Features

There are only two Canon cameras here, so there's not much in the way of awards that will happen here, the IXUS 1000 HS has a CMOS sensor opposed to its siblings' CCD sensor. Neither technology is really much better, although CMOS sensors need to be larger than CCD sensors to provide a similar image quality. Conversely, a CCD sensor will happily chew through battery power 20 times quicker. The IXUS 210 has a much better maximum aperture opening of f2.8 opposed to f3.4. This number is deceptive, and f2.8 is a significant step up from f3.4 – 50 per cent more of light is let into the scene. The IXUS 1000 HS has a trick up its sleeve, in fact two of them, other than the fact that it is a sexy looking camera. Firstly, the compact, slim body masks a substantial 10x optical zoom. Secondly, it can record videos in full HD i.e. 1080p.

These cameras have nice menus – they're not very deep, but they're pretty intuitive. Button placement is pretty decent, we've gone used to the extra buttons on dSLR cameras, but having fewer buttons coupled with more intuitive menus is not a bad thing.

Performance

The Canon IXUS 1000 HS has a pretty lower megapixel rating, and throughout the tests, it offers at least at par, or better, image quality compared to IXUS 210.

Especially in the higher ISO tests, it earns its premium that it is clear to see less smattering of pixels and a marginal amount of greater detail even at base ISOs. To put it plainly, the output from the IXUS 1000 HS at ISO 125, is better than the output produced by the Canon IXUS 210 at ISO 80 – images are cleaner, the flower petals have marginally more detail, and the paper clips are much cleaner and artefact-free. In fact, the IXUS 210 cannot resolve the micro detail around the paper clips, and its evident that the sensor isn't able to capture all the detail involving the texture of the cloth also.

However, we can't really recommend either of these cameras, given that, for their price, they're both a bit short of both features and quality. Actually, neither is a complete package – The IXUS 1000 HS offers a better quality output and has a nicer zoom, but for the price, it isn't as impressive in the higher ISO range as we'd have liked...quite the contrary, we preferred the output of the Nikon S8100 at ISO 800.

ULTRA ZOOM CAMERAS: YOUR WINDOW TO THE WORLD

The ultra zoom was a class of camera created solely for those who need to work with very long zooms and versatile focal lengths. We've seen optical zoom as a growing specification, though this is



Fujifilm S3300

one welcome area of expansion, unlike the alarming growth of megapixels on tiny sensors, the pitfalls of which is increasingly omnipresent noise. Earlier, cameras with optical zooms of up to 20x were considered ultra zooms, today, we have cameras like the Canon SX30 IS with an optical zoom of up to 35x – this makes it very versatile for people even interested in shooting wildlife. Ultra zoom cameras are not for everybody though – they're significantly heavier and bulkier than regular point-n-shoots, and not pocket-friendly. Owing to a large zoom, their optics might also not be up to the optics of a very nice compact camera. However, if you're looking to capture distant objects, you might want to check some of these cameras out. We received three of them, two from Fujifilm and one from Canon.

Features

The SX30 IS from Canon had the longest zoom – 35x. It's a chunky, but not unhandsome camera, with a matte black finish that looks industrial-grade. The outer lens housing is metal, while the inner barrel is plastic. Zooming is creamy smooth, and Canons variable pressure zoom works excellently. The articulating LCD is a plus, and although it's only 2.7-inches, it's a fairly high quality unit. Button placement and ergonomics is good – the SX30 IS has a lot of manual control, and these functions are assigned to dedicated buttons or they work through the onscreen menus – either way we had no issues, although for the record, cameras like Nikon's P7000 and Canon's own G12 are way more intuitive to use. They ain't got the SX30 IS' grip though – finally a chunky grip and given the extra weight, it's needed. Even the thumb